

Dvar Torah Outline — Parashat Re'eh: “Shamor Tishmerun,” Shabbat as “Kol HaMitzvah,” and Shabbat as the Kli for Berachah

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman opens with the Midrash's discomfort: why does Hashem present such harsh קללות to כלל ישראל, and traces the answer through an earlier Midrashic reading of Drawing on the Sfat Emet, Rabbi Shulman explains that Shabbat is “the ”שָׁמור תִּשְׁמְרוּן” one mitzvah that contains all the mitzvot,” and that “guarding Shabbat” means more than refraining from מלאכה—it means cultivating inner stillness. That tranquility allows Shabbat to function as the כלי מחזיק (vessel) that receives and channels Hashem's ברכה into the week.

I. The Midrashic “big picture” problem: harsh in Parashat Re'eh קללות

A. The opening issue

- Rabbi Shulman notes the Midrash at the beginning of the parashah grapples with why Hashem would present such harsh קללות and negative outcomes to כלל ישראל.

B. The Midrash steps back to Parashat Va'etchanan

- To understand Re'eh's ברכה/קללה framing, Rabbi Shulman turns to a Midrashic discussion on a phrase earlier in the Torah: “שָׁמור תִּשְׁמְרוּן” (“Guard you will guard”)—its doubled language demands interpretation.
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II. “את כל המצוה הזאת” as one mitzvah that equals all (1:00)

A. The Midrash’s textual question

- Rabbi Shulman cites the Midrash’s difficulty:
 - :sounds grammatically inconsistent “את כל המצוה הזאת”
 - If it’s one mitzvah → should say “המצוה”
 - If it’s many mitzvot → should say “המצוות”
- Therefore: What is the **one** mitzvah that is also **all** mitzvot?

B. The Midrash’s answer: Shabbat

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Midrash’s conclusion:
 - **Shabbat** is “the one mitzvah that contains all the mitzvot.”
 - Keeping Shabbat is like keeping the whole Torah; violating Shabbat is like rebelling against the whole Torah.
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III. The lamp analogy: reciprocal “guarding” between Hashem and Israel (2:02)

A. “Shamor tishmerun” as conditional reciprocity

- Rabbi Shulman presents the Midrash’s משל:
 - Two people each hold the other’s lamp:
 - “If you guard mine from going out, I’ll guard yours.”
 - “If you let mine go out, I’ll extinguish yours.”
- Applied to Hashem and כלל ישראל:
 - If Israel “guards,” Hashem “guards.”
 - Hashem’s “guarding” = protection from the קללות and harms described.

B. What are we guarding?

- The Midrash says: the Torah.
 - Rabbi Shulman adds (following the Sfot Emet):
 - Since “את כל המצוה הזאת” was defined as **Shabbat**, the “guarding” must apply particularly to **Shabbat**.
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IV. Sfat Emet's penetrating question: does Shabbat need to be guarded? (3:30)

A. The conceptual difficulty

- Rabbi Shulman, quoting the Sfat Emet, asks:
 - What does it mean to “guard Shabbat” as though Shabbat needs protection?
 - If one is מחלל שבת, the damage seems to be **to the person**—so why frame it as doing a “favor” to Shabbat/Hashem’s “thing”?

B. Reframing the question

- The Midrash’s language implies:
 - “You guard My lamp, and I will guard yours.”
 - That suggests Shabbat is not only an obligation for us, but something whose expression in the world depends on us.
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V. Shabbat's “partner”: Israel enables Shabbat to be expressed (4:30)

A. The Midrash of the paired days

- Rabbi Shulman cites a Midrash:
 - Days of creation had partners:
 - 1 with 2, 3 with 4, 5 with 6
 - **Shabbat** was left alone.
- Shabbat “complains,” and Hashem answers:
 - “**כנסת ישראל יהיה בן זוגך**” (Knesset Yisrael will be your partner).

B. What a “partner” means (depth)

- Rabbi Shulman defines “partner” as one who brings potential into expression:
 - Like a spouse enabling completion and “fruitfulness.”
 - So too, Shabbat “needs” Israel:
 - Without כלל ישראל living Shabbat, Shabbat’s קדושה cannot be fully expressed in the world.
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VI. Shabbat as **מקור הברכה** and as a **כלי מחזיק** (6:31)

A. Shabbat channels the week's berachah

- Rabbi Shulman explains (Sfat Emet):
 - Shabbat is **מקור הברכה**—the source that fills the “vessels” of blessing for the coming week.

B. “ויכולו” as “completion” and as “vessel”

- Rabbi Shulman highlights the insight:
 - In Kiddush we say “...ויכולו השמים והארץ.”
 - “ויכולו” can mean
 - Completion (“they were completed”)
 - Or related to **כלי / כל**—“everything” and “vessel,” because “only once there is a vessel can there be ‘everything.’”
- Core principle:
 - Hashem’s **ברכה** requires a **כלי מחזיק**—a container capable of receiving it; otherwise the “pouring” of blessing becomes chaos.

C. Proof from Yeshayahu: “כל” as a כלי

- Rabbi Shulman cites a **פסוק** from **ישעיה** using “כל” in the sense of a vessel:
 - “**מִי מִדָּד בְּשֹׁעָלוֹ מַיִם וְשָׁמַיִם בְּזֶרֶת תִּכֵּן וְכָל בְּשָׁלֹשׁ עֶפֶר הָאָרֶץ...**”
 (“Who measured water with His handful... and contained the dust of the earth in a measure...”)
- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - /here means gathering/containing the earth’s dust into a large “container” **“כל”** measure,” reinforcing the **כלי** meaning.

D. Result: why Shabbat “needs” us

- Shabbat is the **כלי מחזיק** for the week’s berachah.
 - For that berachah to enter the world through Shabbat, Shabbat needs Israel to “partner” with it by properly embodying its **קדושה**.
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VII. “Shmirah” as tranquility: settling the “sediment” so Shabbat can transmit berachah (9:00)

A. “Shamor” also means calm/still

- Rabbi Shulman points to a second meaning:
 - :to guard, but also to be tranquil/restful, like the phrase = “שמר”
 - “הַשְׁמֵר וְהַשְׁקֵט” (“Be calm and be quiet/still”)

B. The משל of wine and “שמרים” (sediment)

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - .are the small grape particles floating in wine after pressing “שמרים”
 - Wine becomes clear and refined only when left **undisturbed** long enough for sediment to settle.
 - That stillness is a kind of “shmirah”—a guarded, undisturbed state that allows clarity.

C. Application to האדם: youth, turbulence, and clarity

- Rabbi Shulman notes (via Mishnah in Avot and the Maharal in Derech Chaim):
 - A young person—even a young חכם תלמיד—is compared to “young wine,” where sediment hasn’t settled.
 - Inner agitation (physical/emotional) prevents full clarity.

D. “Shomer Shabbat” beyond technical non-melachah

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes:
 - Of course Shomer Shabbat includes not doing מלאכות—because מלאכה involves active engagement with עולם הזה and undermines rest.
 - But deeper: Shmirat Shabbat means cultivating **inner tranquility** so the “sediment” of bodily excitement settles.
 - Outcome:
 - Mind and emotions become “pure/translucent” to connect to Shabbat’s holiness.
 - Then Shabbat can function as the כלי that receives and channels berachah: “יכולו השמים והארץ” and “ויכל אלקים.”
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VIII. Choosing berachah: ending back in Parashat Re'eh (13:00)

A. Shabbat-tranquility brings blessing into the world

- Rabbi Shulman concludes that when we provide Shabbat the “shmirah” it needs—inner stillness and faithful Shabbat observance—we draw down berachah for the week and for life.

B. The parashah's charge

- This aligns with Re'eh's opening: Hashem places before us **קללה and ברכה**, and we should choose the **ברכה**.
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IX. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman uses the Midrash to frame Shabbat as “**את כל המצוה הזאת**”—a single mitzvah equivalent to the whole Torah.
- The lamp **משל** teaches reciprocal “guarding”: when Israel guards, Hashem guards—protection from **קללות**.
- The Sfat Emet reframes “guarding Shabbat” as something Shabbat “needs,” because Shabbat's **קדושה** is expressed through its “partner,” **כנסת ישראל**.
- Shabbat is the **מקור הברכה** and **כלי מחזיק** for the week's blessing, hinted in “**ויכולו**.”
- The deepest Shmirat Shabbat is **tranquility**—letting inner “**שמרים**” settle—so Shabbat can transmit berachah into the world.